paper on the table within my reach. Now place the ivory box on the table within my reach. Slide the lid a bit with tongs. Put the tongs on the table. Good! Now you can go and fetch Mr. Culverton Smith, of 13 Lower Burke Street".

I was hesitant to leave him now. He was delirious.

"I have never heard of the name," I said.

"Well, he is the man who has the knowledge of this disease but he is not a medical man. He is a planter. He lives in Sumatra, now visiting London. I didn't want you to go before six, because you wouldn't have found him in his study. I hope you will be able to persuade him to come. You will tell him exactly how you have left me." He said, "You must tell him that I'm dying – plead with him, Watson."

"I'll bring him in a cab," I said.

"No. You will persuade him to come and return before him. Make any excuse. Remember this, Watson."

I saw Mrs. Hudson was waiting outside, trembling and crying. Below, as I waited for the cab, I met Inspector Morton of the Scotland Yard. He was not in his uniform.

"How is he?" asked Inspector Morton.

"He is very ill," I answered.

I reached Mr. Culverton Smith's house. The butler appeared at the doorway. Through the half-open door I heard a man's voice telling the butler, "I am not at home, say so." I pushed past the butler and entered the room. I saw a frail man with bald head sitting. "I am sorry," I said, "but the matter cannot be delayed. Mr. Sherlock Holmes……."

The mere mention of his name had a different effect on the man.

"Have you come from Holmes? How is he?" he asked.

"He is very ill. That is why I have come. Mr. Holmes has a high opinion of you and thought you are the only man in London who can help him."

The little man was startled.

"Why?" he asked.

"Because of your knowledge of the Eastern diseases," I replied.

"How did he get it?" he asked.

I told him everything. He smiled and agreed to come. Pretending that I had some other appointment. I left him. With a sinking heart I reached Holmes' room. I told him that Mr. Smith was coming.

"Well done! Watson!" he said. "You have done everything that a good friend could do. Now you disappear to the next room. And don't speak, or come here."

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